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Jack DeJohnette

NEA Jazz Master Jack DeJohnette is one of the most influential drummers in jazz history. He also has made significant contributions as a pianist, composer, and bandleader.

Jack was interviewed via Zoom on April 7, 2025 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm very pleased to have Jack DeJohnette with me this morning, from your home. You're near Woodstock, is that correct?

JD: Right.

MR: It's a real pleasure to talk to you and I congratulate you on your career. I wanted to start out with something which I just came across, with this particular album of yours which was in our music library for DJs at the college radio station.

JD: Yeah.

MR: And someone had written on the bottom, this is an odd sort of compliment, "susceptible to rip-off, lock it up" which meant the DJs really liked it and they were worried about someone walking away with it.

JD: Oh, okay.

MR: There's a picture inside, I wanted to ask you about. Down in the corner it looks like you, is that you playing into a microphone.

JD: That's me with T-Bone Walker.

MR: With T-Bone Walker. What were you —

JD: T-Bone Walker.

MR: Were you playing a recorder or something?

JD: Oh it was one of those toy saxophones.

MR: I see.

JD: You play into it and you sang, you know, sang the melody.

MR: Almost like a kazoo.

JD: Almost, yeah.

MR: Yes. Well I wonder if you could talk about, you started out as a piano player playing classical music, and then you ended up, still at a young age, playing in bands. And was there a transition where you learned about how music is played without having it notated? And did you learn chords along the way? Was that an exploration of yours?

JD: Yeah I did some of that, but a lot of improvising was involved you know, some of it self-taught, some of it was just you know I had trios and bands in Chicago and you know I

learned on the job you know. And I worked on things at home too you know. Same thing with drums.

MR: When you went out to play gigs, I assume this was sort of in the late '50s, what kind of music made the people happy and that you needed to play?

JD: People liked standards and they liked the blues and good heartfelt jazz you know.

MR: Were you getting a sense of maybe later on some of that experience when you started composing went back to those days when you were playing with saxophone players and getting an idea of how to orchestrate and arrange. Did you ever have formal lessons in that?

JD: No. You know I'm self taught at that. So you know I know what I hear when I write music for the players and their concepts like Duke Ellington did, he used to write for all the personalities in his orchestra you know. So he wrote that way so the composition would bring the most out of the player, you know, and that that would be a reciprocal exchange in the dialogue, the musical dialogue.

MR: What about changing keys for a different situation, if you're backing up a singer or even yourself. Did you start to get this idea that the song is the same in any key, you just have to think of the one and the six and the two and the five and so forth. Did that start to sort of gel in your head?

JD: Well I just automatically transfer it to any key. You know. And quickly pick out the chord changes and you know you had to do that with singers. Some singers just — they might sing in a different key the same song. But you know most of the singers knew what they wanted, what key they wanted to sing in.

MR: Yeah instead of getting a singer who goes, "Well my first note is [hums]" and you have to sort of figure it out yourself.

JD: Yeah.

MR: Well was this playing gigs at a young age, and you had supportive parents, is that correct?

JD: Well my mother, my mother supported me. My father did but they were separated.

MR: Did you get a sense that you could make a living at this, and when did this occur for you? Was it gradual or did you just decide obviously this is what I'm going to do for my career?

JD: Well you know I was playing drums and piano and then one day I just was looking out the window and I just said hmpf, you know, I'm rich, I'm rich. Because the music had given me so much, I just felt that I would make a career of the music and it would provide me with financial abundance, which it has.

MR: You said something in an interview I watched recently, an interview-artist series. And you used the term "I recognized that I had talent to offer." And I thought it was an

interesting way of saying that. Instead of "I have talent that I can make money off of, that you said it's something that you could offer.

JD: Um hum. Well that comes back, yeah I think you know an artist, a musician, a dancer you know has to at least recognize or have a sense of what they have to offer. And I think that helps, especially when you go out to play, you have a positive intention to lift the spirits of the audience up when you play.

MR: Did you play for dancers on those gigs and did it give you some kind of lesson about tweaking music so people really sort of get into it?

JD: Yeah I mean it was different types of dances going on and things like the cha-cha-cha and certain other things like — actually people played to some swing music too, also, and some pop music also. So yeah generally that worked out pretty good.

MR: And were you playing early rock & roll like Chuck Berry and Little Richard, that kind of thing?

JD: Yeah and what's the name — Fats Domino. And I also spent a little time in a cappella doo-wop groups too, singing with them.

MR: I read that you had perfect pitch. I wonder if they depended on you for that?

JD: Yeah I mean we'd find the keys till we knew what was right. And also we were covering, you know, get the pitch off the recording.

MR: Uh huh. Everybody learned their parts by ear at that time?

JD: Oh yeah.

MR: Well before you left Chicago, is that when you had an interaction with the members of the AACM? Can you tell me about that?

JD: Well it wasn't the AACM when I was there. I left the year before the AACM was formed. But the year before that one of my mentors, Muhal Richard Abrams formed the, oh what was it – the Orchestra — Experimental Orchestra. So Roscoe and Joseph Jarman and Malachi Favors, we were all sort of playing in that orchestra, and formed small groups from that orchestra. But then I left the next year and then that's when Roscoe Mitchell and I think Joseph Jarman, Anthony Braxton I think, yeah. That's when it was officially formed, the AACM. So I always get associated with that. I mean even today you know, I still do things with Roscoe Mitchell and Wadada Leo Smith and Henry Threadgill, well that connection has remained over all these years.

MR: Was their approach to music startling to you or just something —

JD: Not really. I mean they all studied all kinds of music. You know? Muhal studied composition and so the music wasn't jazz necessarily it was just new music. Because they would write symphonies, they would write you know, for small ensembles, which would veer into classical range but with room for improvisations in it. So these guys

really were like flying under the radar because they were getting commissions to do, to perform this music, their music.

MR: Yeah, they had to reach out and find those resources and I'm glad that it was available to them. Later on when they went to Paris and so forth, did you stay in touch with that music and want to pursue some of that yourself or maybe you already were? You know I'm skirting around this phrase "free jazz." And I'm wondering if that term is relevant to the way you think. Because I know people sometimes say it's not free it's just something else.

JD: No you know all those guys, it's like they didn't like the term free jazz, that was something that the press connotated, like they did bebop. The musicians never called the music any of those titles. But they kind of stayed because they'd already written about it in the jazz publications. But you know they never thought of that music as free, I mean free in the sense that it was studied and well organized and deeply felt. So they called it — what'd they say — they called it not free music but oh —

MR: Well it was creative, that's for sure.

JD: Yeah. It wasn't free jazz. I mean if you say that something is really free, free from what? I mean when one improvises from study and playing and practicing, one then becomes a spontaneous composer. So anything improvised can be written out and that can become a composition or transcribed. So I always, I think of it as spontaneous composition, not to say it's better than written but two things are interchangeable I think.

MR: Speaking of composition, I'm curious, can you recall one of the first compositions you wrote and did it come from an inspiration or just a curiosity to see if I can actually write something down?

JD: Well you know I think I wrote improvising on the piano, so out of the improvisations would come compositions. Sometimes a composition was written because I had a title before I did the composition. So the composition, the title fit the outcome of the composition.

MR: Could you give me an example of that? I think it's interesting that you would have a title and then write around it. Can you recall one of your early tunes like that?

JD: Let's see. Early compositions. Well I wrote a composition when I had a group called Directions. And the first album we did on ECM I wrote a composition called "Malibu Reggae." And to me it was a musical, trying to say portrait of Malibu, California. And so I added the genre of reggae to it. So it was kind of a playful piece, really.

MR: Do you do that at the piano for the most part? Start your tunes at the piano?

JD: Yeah most of the time I do but sometimes I just whistle a melody or get something from playing the drums or get a rhythm or groove or something like that.

MR: Do you, can you tell me about, I'm going to try to hum a tune of yours that really just has found a place in my head, and see if I can read my own transcription [hums]. Does that ring a bell with you?

JD: I don't hear enough of it.

MR: Yes. It's the piece, your tribute to Erik Satie. Your solo piano work.

JD: Oh you mean from the Newvelle solo, yeah. Yeah no I love Satie, so I just decided to let my intuition write that. So instead of it being in 3/4 like "Gymnopedie" is, I wrote it in 4/4. But I did use some of the, shall we say the things that Satie used in "Gymnopedie." And it's like F sharp, which is like a half-step down from where "Gymnopedie" is, which is in G. And also the bridge went to E flat and then back to F sharp.

MR: When you got to the end of that, writing it, or near the end, was there a debate in your mind about — because I noticed you ended it in the relative minor where the bridge had gone. And it leaves a different impression, at least for me, than if you had played like a lovely F sharp major 7 or something like that. Do you recall why you made that decision?

JD: Well I made it because Satie's tunes ended on a minor. So that was paying tribute to Satie that way.

MR: It's interesting, like many people I think the first time I heard his version was at the beginning of that Blood, Sweat & Tears record and they did only the first part and of course it was really gorgeous. And then when I finally heard the whole thing I said wow there's a lot more to this, because it gets a little dark as it goes along, and quite memorable.

JD: Yup.

MR: Did you choose F sharp for a reason? I mean I know that it related to his piece but it certainly is a little more, you have to be a little more careful I would think, in your note choices. At least for me.

JD: Well it was easy for me because I left space for notes, however I got maybe a little busy in the E flat B section. But you know [scats] you know it's still in the vein of Satie. But it's in 4/4 so it has the flavor of a 3/4 but 4/4 gives it another color.

MR: For sure. I was speaking to Buster Williams once and he said that jazz has made me fearless. And I wonder if you feel something like that? Because you've done so many things, some really on the cutting edge of where things were going, and you're not afraid of challenges. Is that a fair statement?

JD: Yeah I like the challenges actually. Because it helps you grow and helps you develop. You gain more, like I say, wisdom for jazz, some of the challenging music that you have to play. I had to play I mean.

MR: Do you remember a particular recording project where that really came to the forefront? Like I — this is new for me and I have to really bring my A game here. And of course I

think you probably always bring your A game but do you recall a situation where you felt really challenged?

JD: Well you know when I play more arranged music, you know, I have the artist send me an audio version of what they have in mind and send me the music. And so I spend time with that so when I get to the studio I'm ready to go. I know the arrangement without having a read it. So that's what I do with challenging music. I think Joanne Brackeen wrote some very challenging music for Eddie Gomez. She writes a lot of chords and a lot of chords that move fairly fast. Two bars, two beats, one bar. So that was really challenging. But you know that expanded my ability to be comfortable with more complex arrangements.

MR: That's a very interesting answer because I would have assumed that the challenge might have been more along the lines of no arrangements, as if this is going to be open to where you want to go. So I really appreciate you enlightening me about that.

JD: Yeah.

MR: I heard you probably in around 1968 or so, with Charles Lloyd. And I'd had a couple of — I'll call them epiphanies now but that was another one. This was in Rochester in some hall, and I think it was the first time I'd heard drummers and bassists really — I'll call it playing with the time. Not straight ahead but a little bit of elastic approach to the time.

JD: Well the elastic approach to the time I think I would credit Bill Evans and Paul Motian and Scott LaFaro for that kind of free, open-it-up freedom for each individual to be playing collectively but have an equal input. And so after that "Live at the Village Vanguard" you know it kind of just spread throughout the jazz community. So you know you could break time up. Break it up. And then go into the time later. But for coloring it really opened that up.

MR: Is it possible to feel the time — I'm thinking of Latin music with the clave that is almost always there but sometimes no one's playing it. So I guess I'm trying to relate that to a jazz situation where everybody's feeling it but — I can't quite finish this question but it's an interesting thing to observe and hear when the time is there but no one is enforcing it regularly.

JD: Well you could call that freedom. Everybody maybe has an option to play the form or play time or not, or play off of the other musicians' improvisations. So, especially if you're not playing a composition that's written. But you can do it in both cases whether you spontaneously compose or with a composition that we make permutations of.

MR: You had an association with Karl Berger and the Creative Music Studio. Can you tell me how that came about and how you think about your contributions to that now, in retrospect?

JD: I think Karl Berger, I think Ornette has something to do with that. I just came and did some teaching with the students. And then we had Dave Holland, we had Colin Wolcott, what's his name — Trilok Gurtu So there were a lot of current musicians that were like on the faculty teaching there. And so you know the challenge was for us, when we first started, was to play — to get the musicians who were at different levels of being able to play. Some couldn't even play scales. Some — and so we had to try to figure out a way to get, include everybody. As time went on players got better. But so that was a challenge. But it sort of became like a — what do you call it — I think it's become like sort of a legend. There's been books out on it and, you know, my wife Lydia did put together some concerts to raise money to help Creative Music Studio. So yeah, I mean it's still going on. It's different now. Karl has passed away. But I think it's served a purpose for young, aspiring musicians.

MR: He said an interesting thing that, he said, "Playing free requires more discipline, more stringent than anybody can tell me from the outside. The more precise you get, the more free you are." And I remember when he said that I just like — wow — that if you observe it and listen to it you may get the impression that people are just playing randomly and that's not what he's about at all.

JD: Who are you talking about?

MR: Karl Berger.

JD: Oh. Yeah, no he had some discipline, he had some exercises that you do, like something called GaMaLaTaki you know GaMaLaTaki GaMaLaTaki Taki Taki Taki Taki GaMaLaTaki Gamala you know. So it breaks up the time. And then doing that, mixing it up is like what do you call that, code for computer which is ones and zeroes. But they're broken up in different ways. And so then, that's what he means, it's discipline of counting and making permutations with those sounds and it gives the player an opportunity to focus more on what they're doing in improvisation, you know for that kind of direction in learning music.

MR: Would he have people work with that rhythm and those consonants and syllables with just one pitch? Like to play just one pitch on those things to sort of get into it?

JD: Well it wasn't a pitch, you know you just said it wherever they came out. Yeah. It's about rhythm. More about rhythm than pitch.

MR: I wish I had gone. He described a roomful of musicians all playing at the same time and fine tuning it with the notes you picked and finding the balance. It just sounded like a really interesting experiment. There's no question there, but I guess he moved the music forward for sure.

JD: Oh yeah he made a contribution for sure.

MR: In the '70s am I correct that you and your wife created Creative Music Agency?

JD: No.

MR: No. Okay. This is a misnomer then.

JD: Yeah, no. She, you know we helped him you know when they were having some financial problems, Lydia and I — or Lydia arranged and shall we say fundraised the concert. And a lot of prominent musicians came to play there you know — Chick — he told Anthony Braxton, John Abercrombie, Colin Wolcott. So you know that's where the contribution is — a contribution of giving like a free concert to raise money for CMS. But we were never on a board or anything like that. CMS had their own people doing that, managing the place.

MR: What effect do you think your piano skills have on your approach to drumming, or perhaps vice versa. There's been a number of drummers who play piano and you're the most prominent one I can think of, and I wonder how those two things work together, if they effect one another?

JD: Oh they work great. Rhythmically it helps me when I'm playing piano. And the piano helps my drumming in terms of how to tune the drums, you know having fine tuning. Having maybe five or six notes that when you play, you play around the kit, you're always playing melody. So you can make up melodies from that. So one feeds the other. But the piano I say is the basis for shall we say melodic drumming, or melodic and harmonic drumming. It comes from the piano. Like the cymbals are like a sustain pedal with the tom-toms and snares immersed in between.

MR: Do you tune your drums to a particular — in a particular way? I remember one time playing with a drummer who was trying to get a chord and it was the first time I'd noticed that. Do you do such a thing?

JD: No I just tune by my intuition, by ear — I hear a pitch I like and then I go to the other tom. And you know make a nice melodic sequence.

MR: I was happy to see — I have the whole collection of Marian McPartland's "Piano Jazz" and you did a session with her.

JD: Right.

MR: And there's a quote in here from you, "I got around so well on Miles' music because I like the unexpected." Was "Bitches Brew" an unexpected situation for you or had you been sort of set up for that?

JD: Yeah I was set up and prepared. I'm from Chicago, where I played various kinds of music. So I didn't have any biases toward all the so-called genres of music. You know "Bitches Brew" was basically kind of a jam session with — not highly arranged, but with, you know, melodic interludes in between things. And then Miles let the tapes roll and got a groove that he liked and then he would play or somebody — Bennie Maupin would play, different players would solo on top of that. And then through Teo Macero,

his producer, through his artistry of putting all the different tracks together to tell a story, he did that very well.

MR: I'm trying to picture you and the other musicians, the first time you heard the final product. Did you like it?

JD: Yeah. That's what I meant by Teo. Teo put the sequence together in a way that told a story.

MR: Don Alias had something to say about the session that was kind of similar. I assume that you were sort of in a circle around miles logistically? Is that how that worked?

JD: Not around Miles, no.

MR: Oh okay.

JD: Miles had his own place with a speaker so he could hear everything.

MR: How does it work in this business these days with — do you get payments for things you did over the years, or was it mostly you got a fee? I guess I'm talking about the many things you've done as a side person. Do you ever get checks in the mail and wonder what is this for?

JD: Not from doing that. I mean you know I get fees that I suggest or demand that I get. You know you get a 1099 and do that. I mean there's checks that would be like say Erykah Badu did an album called "Kiss Me on My Neck" and she sampled a track from my, what was it, "Sorcery" album. And she used it on two tracks but they never contacted my lawyer about the copyright of that. So as a result of that, a statutory rate, my lawyer got on there, paid us, paid Dave and I quite a sum over time you know.

MR: Well it's nice to know the system finally worked in that technology moves so quickly, do you think that composers and players these days write differently because of what's possible in the recording studio with all the things you can do digitally and if someone's a bit off it's very fixable. I guess I'm just generally asking you how you feel about the state of technology in the music world?

JD: It's fine. The creative aspect of it depends on the musician. You can go out as far as you want to go, or be as organized as you want. You know the tools are there, it's the humans that make the difference. You know it's the humans that turn out the music, not an AI machine.

MR: Um hum. I'll run a few names by you and just wonder if you have a comment or association that you might share with me. One would be Howard Johnson.

JD: Yeah well Howard was a unique musician in the sense that he played tuba and saxophone and played trumpet. And he was a good composer/arranger. And he arranged a beautiful version of "Monk's Mood" on the "Album Album." At the time I was using an electric melodica so I could add another voice to the arrangement. It was really great. A very talented guy.

MR: I was just listening to that this morning and your "New Orleans Strut" that you wrote I think for your father is very hooky. Really sticks in your head.

JD: I actually didn't write it for my father, I wrote it for the music that comes from New Orleans. You know, and actually the drum beat I kind of used on there is from like s/l Zigaboo*** 45:36 who plays with the — what do you call it — what's the last name — you know the which is made up of — I can't think of the names right now. But yeah I mean I like that kind of second line groove. So that was a kind of tribute to New Orleans.

MR: Yeah. A wonderful chart. How about Sun Ra? Did you have an interaction with him early on?

JD: Yeah. I played with him a lot in Chicago with the Arkestra and then after I came to New York, he came after that. And I played some gigs with him in New York too. So Sun Ra was like an enigma. You know he talked about space a lot. I think when the synthesizers came out he loved that, because he was always hearing some space stuff. But he was a, dare I say a phenomena in the fact that right now the Arkestra is still going on, led by 100-year-old — oh what's his name?

MR: Marshall Allen?

JD: Marshall Allen. Yeah. I played with Marshall back then. You know? And Ronnie Boykins, John Gilmore. So yeah it was definitely fun and definitely I found Sun Ra very interesting. He used to read sci-fi comic books and he definitely believed he was from Saturn. So I think some of that was ahead of his time in a way, some of the pieces he wrote. The interplanetary music. And so yeah, he still sustains today. I'm glad that I was part of some of that.

MR: There's probably albums with — actually we have a Sun Ra collection here at Hamilton and he seemed to record constantly.

JD: Yup. He liked to keep a musical record of what he was doing. And so, and he had benefactors that, you know, made it possible for his music to be made public.

MR: How about, this is not a person but a record label, ECM? Did you feel that you needed to adjust your style when you played for that —

JD: Not really, because actually it was actually freeing because Manfred Eicher, the producer there, wanted to bring out the best situation, an artistic situation, in music. And it was actually my cymbal work got amplified on a lot of recordings of ECM because Manfred liked detail. And he also liked spontaneity as well as written compositions. And also ECM had a sound that people really liked, and an artistic thing with the covers and it's still going on today. So it was more about the art of the music rather than thinking about something commercially. It still is. You know Keith and the Koln concerts, they never figured that would be as popular as it was. You know it was just a moment in time, but also ECM had a good distribution set up for a while, and then the musicians were touring

and they also supported the musicians on their recordings, their touring. So yeah I mean I had a lot of fun recording for ECM. I had my old bands, other good musicians, Keith Jarrett and Gary Peacock's Standards Trio. So yeah, there was a lot of room to experiment but at a high level of creativity.

MR: Do you save — let me rephrase, I'm sort of surrounded here by a number of your LPs and CDs and I'm wondering if you have a personal collection of Jack DeJohnette recordings? Do you save everything that you do?

JD: Yeah as a matter of fact I have an archive, my wife and my assistant Joan Clancy spent quite a lot of time organizing for me. But you know I recorded in different formats: cassettes, DATs, reel-to-reel. Anyway you were going to ask me about favorite albums?

MR: Yeah. I wondered if someone tried to pin you down about the recordings that you're most proud of, is there a short list?

JD: Well yeah, one is called "Fifth World Anthem," it's dedicated to the Native American sensibility and a teacher named Grandmother Twylah Nitsch. So she was very much an inspiration for that. And Miles was inspiration for that too. Oh what else?

[long pause]

Let's see the Special Edition "Album Album"

[pause]

Oh yeah, there's an album Keith and I, which is a duet album called "Ruta and Daitya." What else? Also the first album I did with our group Special Edition, which had Arthur Blythe, not Arthur Blythe — well yeah, the first one I did for ECM is called

[pause]

Special Edition which had Arthur Blythe and David Murray and Peter Warren in it. So yeah I liked the writing on there and the improvisations. And then there's another Special Edition album

[pause]

Yeah, a Special Edition album, yeah, the first album I did on oh it was another label, I can't remember it now, Impulse or — but yeah, it had Mick Goodrick on guitar, let's see, Lonnie Plaxico on bass and Greg Osby on alto and Gary Thomas on tenor.

MR: I just was looking at the CD Guide to Jazz and they mention both those recordings of yours as whatever critic was writing was very positive about those. A couple of more things before we wrap up, you seem like a patient and thoughtful and calm individual. I wonder if there's things musically in situations that could aggravate you?

JD: I was fortunate enough to take situations where that didn't happen you know. I was always in a situation where I felt that I was at the highest level of creativity and quality so I was fortunate enough to be in those kind of situations. I'd put myself in those situations.

So now I have musical situations now that I'm retired that — where I get together with a group of musicians once a week and we just play for the fun of it. That's great.

MR: Yeah. I'm glad to hear that. Do you have an idea, a hope that people who listen to your music are touched in some way? What is your hope for the music you put out into the world?

JD: I hope people like it. I hope, you know, the radar gets something, or get moved to do something creatively on their own. That's what I hope. That's what I'd like to happen.

MR: As time goes by I've spoken to musicians about searching for their own original sound or being creative, and I wonder if it gets harder as people come and go and they make their contributions and you're trying to find something that hasn't been done before. Does it get harder as the years go by?

JD: Well not if you, you know assess the terrain, what's going on. The most important thing is to find your own voice and just be real with that, and then go from there. And not be in competition, just being yourself. Having something that the music produces and fans can connect to. There's one more album I'd like to say, it wasn't my album but we have archive recordings here, and this is a recording from 1966 at the legendary club Slug's and it's McCoy Tyner, it was McCoy's gig, McCoy Tyner, Joey Henderson, Henry Grimes and myself. I don't know if you heard that yet, you should check it out.

MR: I will.

JD: It is amazing. It is — every time I listen to it, I've listened to it a lot, but I get excited you know, and that's the reaction a lot of people get from hearing music played like that you know.

MR: I had the fortunate circumstance of right next door to this office I'm sitting I had Rashied Ali and Henry Grimes here and that was just wonderful to listen to them talk about music and Rashied said something about, you know you're talking about free jazz and many people think that it sounds angry. And he straightened me out on that, he just said it was the times we were in, it was a reflection of the times, and he did talk about the experiences he had in the military with segregation and so forth, and it was very enlightening.

JD: Yeah. Well you know I know Rashied and he's very interesting. He's a very musical drummer actually. And he found another way of playing, which was a multi — like a sound and a vibration that John Coltrane could play. I mean a lot of people, you know, not only he said it but Rashied used to play a lot of time. In fact I sat in on piano with him at his club Green Street. But he always carried a flute with him. So he's very musical. But he discovered a way to play the drums in such a way that was very concentrated. And I had the opportunity to play with him with John Coltrane in Chicago at the Plugged Nickel with Alice and Jimmy and Pharoah Sanders. And we played a week in Chicago.

And that was amazing. I learned a lot from Rashied just playing next to him. Because I was young and cocky and there I saw Rashied in terms of stamina and focus and concentration you know. I would play full out and then I'd get tired and stop and he'd be playing, he'd still be going. And I realized oh, he figured out a way to create the dynamics with a concentrated effort.

MR: You had a — I'll just wrap up here with a quote you had from this interview I watched yesterday. And you said, "Coltrane would suck up whatever you gave him" and then you actually physically described it. And I thought it was a wonderful image and you had to keep giving it to him. I can see how you'd be exhausted by that.

JD: Yeah, I mean he's like a sponge you know. He absorbed the sound that was around him. So you know it brought out the best in your playing. So yeah, so like I say and others too, he put the "Om" back in jazz.

MR: All right. Well you've had a marvelous career, you came a long way from your first piano teacher that used to whack your knuckles if you didn't do it right

JD: Right.

MR: And you've entered that world of being an influencer, because we always talk about our influences and I know that you've influenced a lot of people in a positive way so I want to thank you for your time today.

JD: Right. Thank you. It was a pleasure.

MR: All right.

JD: Okay man.

MR: Yeah thank you I'll stop recording here and we'll say a quick good-bye.